KERALA

# FIGHT TO THE FINISH

## The Nilambur bypoll, a multi-cornered contest, has become a prestige battle for all players concerned

*By* **Jeemon Jacob**

**THE NILAMBUR BYPOLL** on June 19 will see some political fireworks with a heavyweight four-cornered fight. The election was forced on Kerala after CPI(M)-backed independent MLA and controversial businessman P.V. Anvar resigned after levelling serious corruption charges against the Chief Minister's Office. The bypoll has become a prestige issue for CM Pinarayi Vijayan of the CPI(M), former bastion claimant Congress, and Anvar himself, who is curiously now in the fray for the Trinamool Congress. The BJP has fielded Mohan George, a senior leader of the Kerala Congress (Joseph faction), who only joined the saffron side after it announced him as their candidate.

The Marxists have fielded Nilambur native, ex-MLA and firebrand leader M. Swaraj, while the Congress has named Aryadan Shoukath, Anvar's arch rival and son of the late Aryadan Muhammed who represented the seat for 34 years. Shoukath's candidature has infuriated Anvar further, especially since his rapprochement efforts had been rebuffed. Incidentally, both come from Malabar's top Congress families. Inaugurating the poll campaign on June 1, Pinarayi recalled how Mapillah rebellion hero Variyankunnanath Kunjahammad Haji was betrayed, an oblique reference to Anvar. The latter, though, is unfazed. "I'm no traitor. Nilambur knows who is the traitor. I will teach both Pinarayi and the Congress a lesson," he told INDIA TODAY.

Nilambur has 40 per cent Hindu and Muslim voters each. The CPI(M) has fielded a Hindu, hoping the Muslim votes will get split between Anvar and Shoukath. But the Malabaris are a canny lot, and polling day is sure to bring some surprises. ■





**BATTLE READY** (From left) Anvar, Swaraj and Shoukath

**Takeaways**

- **Controversial MLA P.V. Anvar quits after making allegations against CMO**
- **Nilambur is the heartland of Muslim politics in Kerala, that could affect results**

*By* **Kavitha Muralidharan**

**IN 2008, KAMAL HAASAN ASTONISHED** India with *Dasavatharam*, a film in which he played 10 roles. But few then could have foreseen that versatility extending to a role in politics. Nor, by a long shot, that Kamal would one day be walking into the halls of Parliament. And given his usually genteel, restrained demeanour in public, certainly not that such a stage entry would be accompanied by a surround sound of a bitter language debate, with chauvinism in full flow on all sides.

Yet, here he is, days away from the portals of the Rajya Sabha, but also simultaneously battling a ban called by Kannada activists on his latest release *Thug Life*, complete with irate rebuttals, erudite takedowns and court interventions. All for an off-the-cuff remark on stage, that "Kannada is born out of Tamil".

Though spoken in the fond tones of filial bonding, it stretched the bounds of accuracy and, in retrospect, was the best way to wade foolhardily into a minefield. Even Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah berated him—not quite the script Kamal would have had in mind. He was all dressed up to be the voice of the South in New Delhi.

**STYLE SOUTH, UP NORTH**

Once the dust settles, even if traces of toxicity linger, that larger role is what the plot will move to after the interval. Kamal's arrival in Parliament marks a turning point—not just for him, but for how Tamil Nadu's concerns are articulated nationally. His path till now had been shorn of drama, proceeding instead with precision. His peer Rajinikanth, the one with the high-voltage line to the street, had always appeared much the likelier candidate to renew Tamil cinema's organic links to politics. He toyed with it, teased the public, but finally never made